

ANIMAL WORKSHOP

By using the discipline and exploitation of livestock as a metaphor, this project explores contemporary capitalists' labor exploitation of employees. Inspired by the prevalent 996 work culture, it reflects the relentless pressure and mental exhaustion faced by workers under the drive of corporate capital. While this vicious cycle of overwork may temporarily boost productivity, it ultimately risks leading to counterproductive outcomes.



RESEARCH

Background

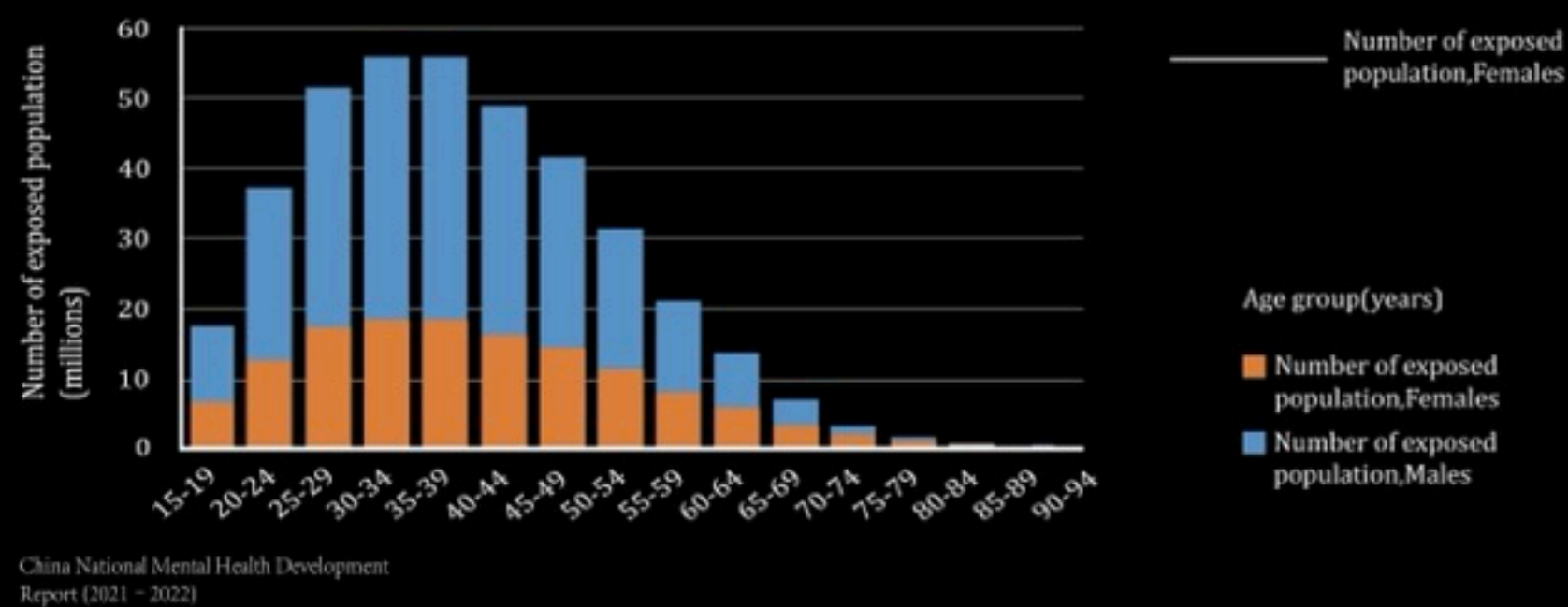
A. The advancement of technology is accelerating the pace of people working alongside machines, rather than slowing it down.

This project is inspired by the widespread 996 culture in today's world, where employees are continuously exploited and drained by corporate capital. This vicious cycle of overwork is boosting productivity—while also leading to backlash.



The term "996" refers to a work schedule of starting at 9 a.m., ending at 9 p.m., and working six days a week, resulting in a total of 72 working hours per week—far exceeding the internationally recognized standard of 40 hours. Many companies, driven by performance metrics and a culture of overwork, force employees to endure excessive working hours, even rebranding "overwork" as a positive notion of "striving for success."

B. Exposure to Prolonged Working Hours



World Health Organization (WHO) and International Labour Organization (ILO) systematic reviews reported sufficient evidence for higher risks of ischemic heart disease and stroke amongst people working long hours (≥ 55 hours/week), compared with people working standard hours (35-40 hours/week). This article presents WHO/ILO Joint Estimates of global, regional, and national exposure to long working hours, for 194 countries, and the attributable burdens of ischemic heart disease and stroke, for 183 countries, by sex and age, for 2010, 2021, and 2023.

C. Evaluation by the Chinese Academy of Social Sciences

Over the past 30 years, discussions surrounding working hours have never ceased. A review of Western literature reveals that the standardized working hour system emerged alongside industrialization, shaped by technological advancements, labor movements, state intervention, and management improvements. However, the so-called "standards" have always been subject to numerous variables in practice. Since the 1980s, with the advent of the post-industrial society, flexible working hours have gradually replaced standardized schedules globally, affecting nearly all industries and various types of workers.



Chinese Academy of Social Sciences Evaluation (2022-2024)

D. Low-Desire Society



Research shows that long working hours, by squeezing personal time and energy, have led to family patterns such as "absentee spouse marriages" and "zombie parenting," exacerbating individuals' negative attitudes toward marriage and childbirth. Moreover, chronic overwork has resulted in frequent psychological issues such as fatigue, anxiety, and depression, with several cases of employee sudden deaths sparking public criticism of corporate exploitation. This work system not only violates labor laws but also severely disrupts the balance between work and life, leading to strained family relationships and a decline in quality of life.

STARTING POINT

Background

In response to the growing impact of this phenomenon, there has been an increase in protests and satirical expressions within society. This, in turn, has led to frequent social conflicts and a decline in the vibrancy of the living environment.

A. The Emergence of the Term "Cattle and Horse Workers"



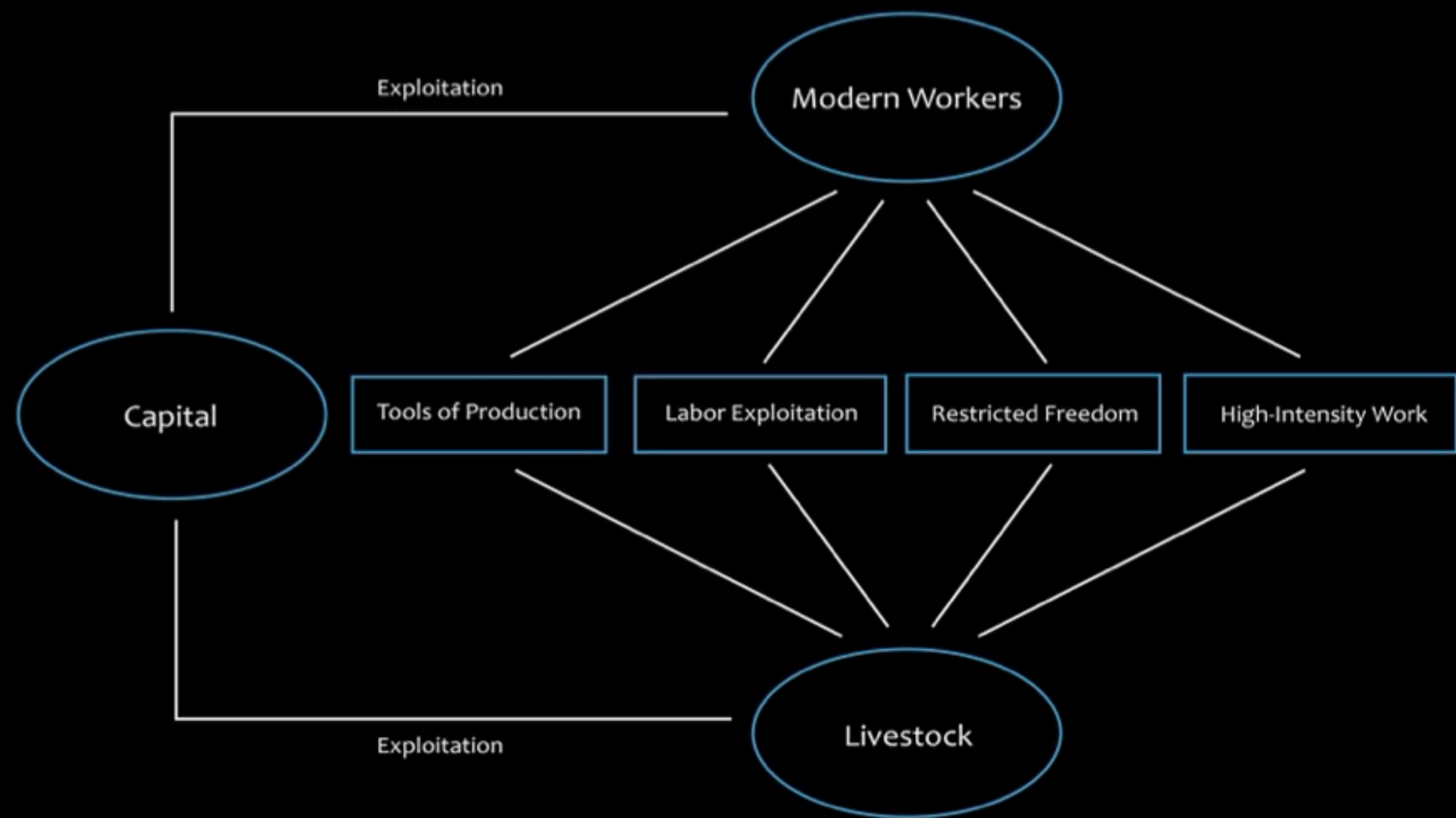
The term "cow and horse" originally referred to a metaphor for the hard-working lives of grassroots laborers. In recent years, this phrase has regained popularity on online platforms, becoming a buzzword among young people to mock intense workloads and their own working conditions. Widely spread through short videos and social media, it now reflects not only the pressures of labor but also serves as a satire and critique of modern workplace dynamics.

B. How Do Humans Treat Working Animals?



Throughout human civilization, working animals such as cattle and horses have been regarded as essential tools of production, taking on heavy tasks such as farming, transportation, and pulling carts in warfare. Humans have domesticated and strictly controlled these animals, restricting their freedom to fully serve production needs. While some cultures attribute qualities like loyalty or resilience to these animals, they are mostly treated as mere tools, often facing slaughter or abandonment once their productivity declines.

Commonalities:



Driven by the logic of capital, both modern workers and working animals are regarded merely as tools of production, with their value reduced to a reflection of productivity. Through high-intensity labor and restricted freedom, capital not only perpetuates control over labor but also deepens the alienation of humanity and the meaning of life. Therefore, I applied the tools traditionally used to control, exploit, and harm working animals onto humans, altering their context and adapting them to human bodies. This approach serves to satirize capitalism's insatiable desire for economic gain and its disregard for the existence of any form of life.

OUTCOME 1

Props Part 1



To explore the phenomenon of contemporary capitalists' labor exploitation of employees, I used the discipline and exploitation of animals as a metaphor. Utilizing some of the most common tools used to control animals, I reimagined them in a "humanized" design under the brand "Cattle and Horse Workers' Workshop." This approach highlights the parallels between the treatment of animals and modern workers.



"Cattle and Horse Workers' Workshop" is a conceptual brand I created, using humanity's excessive control and exploitation of animals as a metaphor to explore the relentless demands and unreasonable constraints capital imposes on employees. This serves as a critique of the profound impact and harm such practices inflict on individuals and society. Through this work, I hope to inspire a world with more joy and balance.

Cattle Nose Ring	A nose ring is inserted into the nose of an animal, primarily used to control bulls. It is installed and secured through a piercing in the nasal septum or the edge of the nose.	Dog Collar	Worn around the necks of many pets, a collar is used for control, identification, or other purposes.
			
Sheep Ear Tag	An ear tag is a notch or marker placed on the ears of livestock such as cattle, pigs, sheep, or camels, used to indicate ownership, year of birth, or gender.	Horse Bit	The horse bit, in conjunction with the reins, allows the rider to control the horse's head. The bit applies pressure to the horse's mouth and enhances other control signals from the rider's legs and weight distribution.
			

OUTCOME 1

Props Part 2

In this part, I will wear the metaphorical animal props I created and conduct physical photoshoots. This is aimed at achieving a better visual effect while also satirizing how capital treats workers in the same way as livestock.

1. Employee ID Badge Design

This ear tag design is inspired by the traditional large ear tags used for cattle, combined with informational elements from human employee ID badges, such as employee numbers, photos, and job titles.



2. Employee Branding Design

This design is inspired by the branding traditionally used on livestock, with employee numbers and personal information QR codes branded onto the back of the neck, symbolizing identification and ownership.

3. Employee Tag Design

This ear tag design is modeled after the small-scale ear tags used for sheep, emphasizing simplicity and adaptability, while also incorporating human employee information elements.



4. Employee Mouthpiece Design

This design is inspired by the horse bit, worn on the human body, symbolizing enforced control and restraint over the individual.

5. Employee Collar Design

This design is based on a dog collar, incorporating the branding of "Cattle and Horse Workers' Workshop." The attached tag displays the employee's phone number, job title, and physical appearance, complemented by a decorative bell.



6. Employee Nose Ring Design

This design is inspired by the cattle nose ring, incorporating the branding of "Cattle and Horse Workers' Workshop." It symbolizes the control and restraint imposed by capital on individuals.



This design draws inspiration from the reality of birds having their throats slit, applying the stitched throat motif to employees as a symbol of the deprivation and suppression of speech. It metaphorically represents the expectation for employees to remain silent and focus solely on their work.

OUTCOME 2

Print Media Part 1

This series of print designs is based on a newspaper-style layout, juxtaposing cases of overworked livestock with those of employees enduring excessive overtime. By drawing parallels, the works highlight the ruthless nature of capital exploitation.



Newspaper Design: Page Two

2. Black and White Tone

The overall black-and-white tone symbolizes the opposition between oppression and resistance. Black represents the indifference and oppression of capital, while white symbolizes fragile hope and suppressed humanity.

3. Title Significance



- 1. Highlight Key Information
- 2. Strengthen Logic
- 3. Enhance Visual Effects
- 4. Create Reading Rhythm
- 5. Reinforce Expression Focus



1. Red Seal Stamp

The red quality inspection mark, originally used to indicate whether livestock was qualified after slaughter, is incorporated into the design to symbolize the objectified fate of workers and animals under the capitalist system.

STOP CRYING



4. Image Selection

The images, featuring elements such as animals, machinery, skyscrapers, and groups of workers, illustrate the continuity of labor exploitation from history to the modern era.



OUTCOME 2

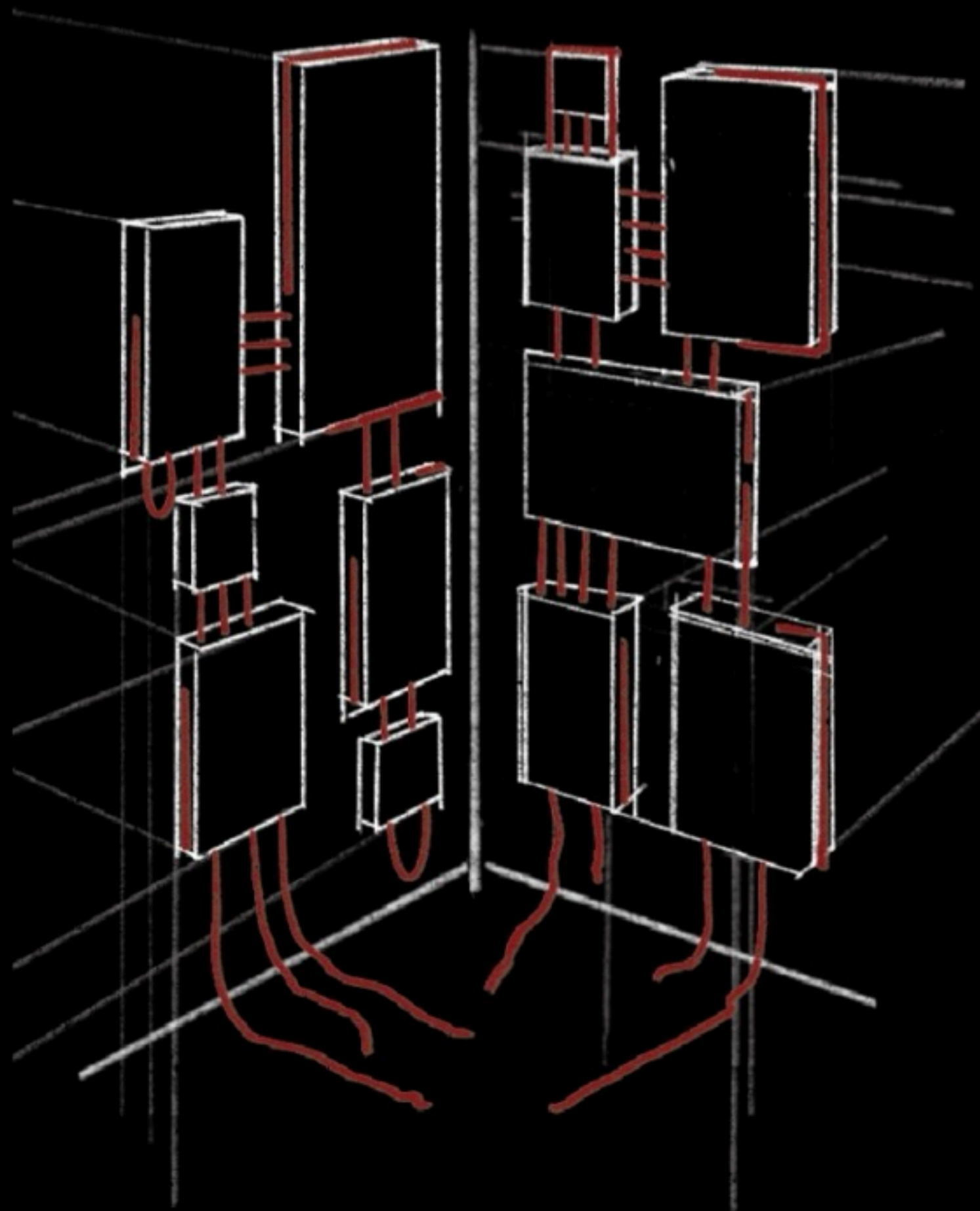
Print Media Part 2



OUTCOME 3

Curatorial Section 1

This exhibition presents the photographed images framed and connected by transparent tubes, simulating the process of blood extraction.



Curatorial sketch

1. Bloodsucking

Transparent tubes connect the frames, simulating the process of "blood extraction," symbolizing capital's exploitation of workers. The "blood" flows into containers, metaphorically representing the plundering of labor's output by capital.



2. Print Media

The graphic design uses the newspaper as a vehicle to incorporate the design of the 'Cattle and Horse Workers Workshop,' which contrasts cases of exploitation between livestock and employees.



3. Collection

The collection containers, consisting of buckets and bags of blood, are labelled 'Workshop for Cattle and Horse Workers', detailing the source and quality of the 'healthy and nutritious blood'.



4. Display

Hay is spread at the exhibition's base, symbolizing the environment of livestock and metaphorically representing the objectification of workers. This reinforces the theme of capital exploitation and enhances the immersive experience of the scene.



Personal Creation Process



OUTCOME 3

Curatorial Section 2

